

MOBILE TOWER DEPLOYMENT AND THE TOWERCO MARKET IN CANADA



*A Strategic, Regulatory and Market Reference for Investors,
Executives and Infrastructure Sponsors*

B² ADVISORY

Independent Telecom & Infrastructure Advisory

FREE PREVIEW EDITION

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This preview contains the front matter, Executive Summary and Section 1 of the full 47-page report.

What you're reading

This is a free excerpt of Mobile Tower Deployment and the TowerCo Market in Canada, a proprietary B² Advisory research report. It reproduces the confidentiality notice, executive summary and Section 1 (Market Overview and Total Addressable Market) in full and unedited form. Sections 2 through 14, the glossary, and the full sourced appendix are withheld from this edition — see the outline on the next page for everything the complete report includes.

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The full report runs 47 pages across 14 analytical sections plus a glossary and a fully sourced methodology appendix, with five proprietary data exhibits. The two entries marked ✓ Included below are reproduced in full in this preview; everything else is available only in the complete, purchased edition.

- ✓ Included in this preview — Executive Summary
- ✓ Included in this preview — 1. Market Overview and Total Addressable Market
- 2. Ownership, M&A History and Valuation Benchmarking
- 3. Regulatory Architecture — Who Does What
- 4. Planning Phase
- 5. Permitting Process by Regulatory Body
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- Appendix A. Methodology and Sources
- Appendix B. About B² Advisory

Get the complete report

The full edition includes the ownership and M&A history behind Canada's TowerCo transition, valuation benchmarking against global public tower REITs, the complete federal/municipal/aeronautical permitting stack, structural standards and deployment timelines, tenant-addition economics, network operations and maintenance, health and safety governance, risk factors, and a forward-looking outlook — assembled for investors, executives and infrastructure sponsors evaluating exposure to this market.

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Executive Summary

Canada's mobile tower infrastructure market is undergoing its most significant structural change in a generation. Until 2025, Canadian wireless carriers owned roughly **95% of their own towers** — a striking outlier against the United States, where independent tower companies (TowerCos) have owned roughly 97% of the market for decades. In the space of about eighteen months, that has begun to change: two independent tower platforms, **Terrion** (spun out of TELUS, 49.9% owned by La Caisse) and **Aurora Towers** (built by CVC DIF from the former SBA and, pending close, American Tower Canadian portfolios), now collectively control several thousand sites, and a federal proposal to modernize the decades-old site-approval process is working its way through consultation.

This Report brings together the regulatory architecture, market sizing, transaction history, valuation benchmarks, deployment economics, and operational and safety framework that govern how a Canadian tower is planned, permitted, built, financed, maintained and eventually monetized — assembled specifically for investors, executives, and infrastructure sponsors evaluating exposure to this market, whether through direct investment, an advisory mandate, or strategic planning.

Key findings

- **The market is real but still small and early-stage.** Independent research values the Canadian telecom towers market at approximately US\$890 million in 2025, growing to a forecast US\$1.1 billion by 2031 (3.56% CAGR) — a market that is growing, but from a much smaller base and a much shorter independent-ownership history than the U.S. or Western European TowerCo markets (Section 1).
- **Ownership is consolidating quickly, but along two very different structural paths.** Terrion (~3,000 towers, four provinces, majority TELUS-owned and controlled) and Aurora Towers (650-plus sites post the pending American Tower transaction, all ten provinces, arm's-length multi-tenant ownership) represent two fundamentally different investment propositions dressed in similar “Canadian TowerCo” language — one a financed carrier vehicle, the other a genuinely independent platform (Section 2).
- **Deployment remains slow relative to mature TowerCo markets.** A new macro site realistically takes 18–26 months from land acquisition to operation, driven by a 120-day municipal consultation window, up to 60 business days for aeronautical clearance, and CSA S37 structural engineering — though rooftop and monopole builds can move materially faster where regulatory exemptions apply (Sections 5–8).
- **A federal reform that could compress those timelines is not yet finalized.** ISED's proposed amendments to CPC-2-0-03 (Gazette notice DGSO-001-26) remain in consultation as of this Report's data-current date; current delivery benchmarks should be treated as the baseline, not as already reflecting a streamlined process (Section 2.5).
- **Valuation benchmarks exist at the transaction level but not yet at the EBITDA-multiple level.** Canadian deals imply roughly US\$0.6–0.9 million of enterprise value per tower; global public tower REITs trade at 18–19x EV/EBITDA and private portfolios typically 15–22x, but no Canadian transaction to date has disclosed the underlying EBITDA needed to compute a directly comparable multiple (Section 2.4).



- **Tenant-addition economics, not new-build volume, are the near-term value driver.** Reinforcing or extending an existing, already-permitted tower is typically a fraction of new-build cost and captures colocation rent approaching what a first tenant would pay — the core reason both Terrion's and Aurora Towers' investment theses lean on tenant additions to already-owned towers rather than speculative new construction (Section 9).
- **Health, safety and labour jurisdiction has just been authoritatively clarified.** A July 2026 Federal Court ruling confirmed that tower-services contractors such as WesTower fall under federal Canada Labour Code jurisdiction rather than provincial regimes — a recent, still-developing precedent with direct relevance to counterparty diligence (Section 11).

How to use this Report

Readers assessing a specific transaction or counterparty should pair Sections 1 and 2 (market sizing, ownership and valuation) with Section 12 (risk factors) as the core diligence starting point. Readers focused on operational or development questions — how long a build takes, what a tenant addition costs, how maintenance and safety are managed — will find Sections 5 through 11 organized as a practical reference. Section 13 sets out the catalysts most likely to reshape this market over the next 12 to 24 months, and Section 14 and Appendix A provide a glossary and full methodology and source list respectively for readers who need to trace a specific figure back to its origin.

1. Market Overview and Total Addressable Market

Canada's wireless tower infrastructure sits at an inflection point. A market that was, until 2025, almost entirely carrier-owned is now host to two active independent tower platforms, a live federal proposal to modernize the siting process that governs every new structure, and continuing 5G densification and rural-coverage build-out that keep underlying site demand growing. This section sizes the market, describes the physical asset base behind it, and quantifies the capital intensity of the sector in which that asset base sits.

1.1 Market size and growth

Independent market research (Mordor Intelligence) values the Canada telecom towers market — encompassing tower ownership, leasing and related site-infrastructure revenue — at approximately **US\$890 million in 2025**, rising to an estimated **US\$920 million in 2026** and a forecast **US\$1.1 billion by 2031**, implying a compound annual growth rate of approximately **3.56%** over the 2026–2031 window. Exhibit 1 sets out this trajectory.

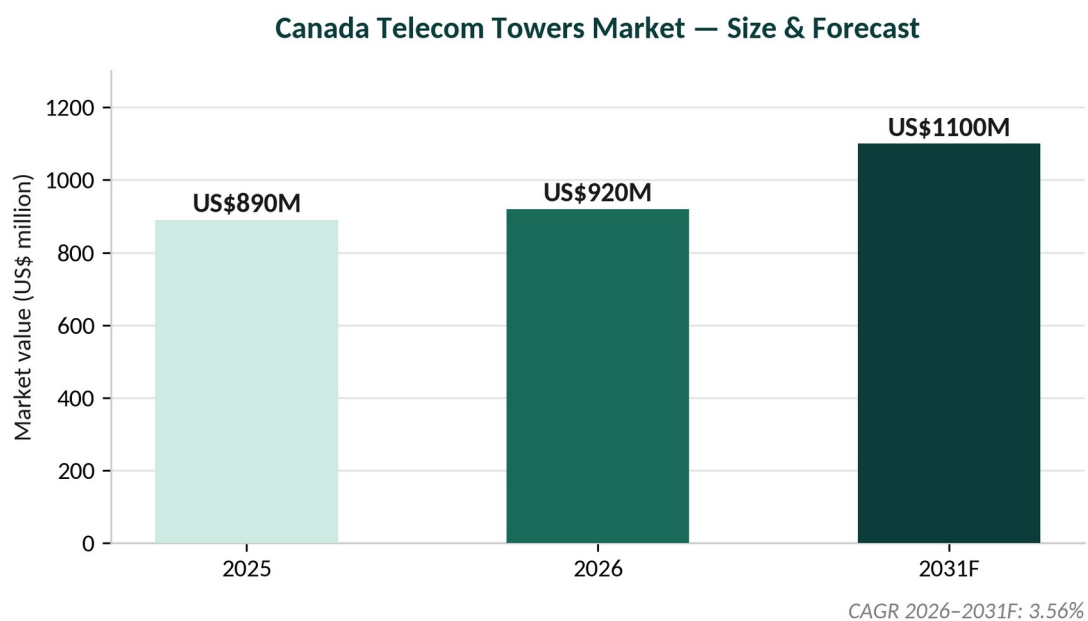


Exhibit 1. Canada Telecom Towers Market size and forecast, US\$ million. Source: Mordor Intelligence, Canada Telecom Towers Market Size & Share Outlook to 2031.

This market-value figure captures site-leasing and related infrastructure revenue rather than the replacement value of the physical asset base; it is best read as the addressable revenue pool that a tower owner, operator, or acquirer is ultimately underwriting when it prices a Canadian tower portfolio.

1.2 Structural drivers of tower demand

- **5G densification:** active antenna units and massive-MIMO radios are markedly heavier and more wind-loaded than the passive antennas they replace, which is driving both new-site demand at the margin and a substantial base of structural reinforcement and tenant-addition work on existing towers (Section 9).

- **Rural and remote coverage funding:** federal and provincial connectivity programs (including initiatives under Canada's Connectivity Strategy) continue to fund new coverage in underserved corridors, a segment ISED itself flags as needing meaningfully more sites — see Section 1.3.
- **Carrier balance-sheet management:** as detailed in Section 2, all three major recent Canadian infrastructure transactions were explicitly framed by their sellers around debt reduction, a dynamic that is structurally supportive of continued monetization activity and, by extension, of transaction volume in the market this report addresses.
- **Regulatory modernization:** ISED's in-progress reform of CPC-2-0-03 (Section 3.1, Section 13) is aimed squarely at compressing the administrative timeline that has historically constrained how quickly new sites and tenant additions can be delivered — a second-order but real demand enabler.

1.3 The physical asset base: how many towers does Canada actually have?

Public disclosure on the size of Canada's physical tower stock is thin and the terminology is not always used consistently across sources, which matters for anyone underwriting a portfolio or benchmarking a target's site count. Two figures, from two different vantage points, anchor the picture:

- **Approximately 13,000 wireless antenna towers** across Canada, per Innovation, Science and Economic Development Canada's own published guidance — understood to capture registered antenna-supporting tower structures specifically (as distinct from rooftop and other non-tower mounting locations), and explicitly described by ISED as “increasing to meet demand.”
- **Roughly 35,000 shared wireless site locations** nationally when rooftop mounts, small cells and other non-freestanding-tower sites are included alongside towers — the broader figure relevant to total network footprint rather than tower-structure count specifically — with industry commentary separately estimating a further **1,200–1,500 additional towers** will be needed to extend rural coverage, and the Greater Toronto Area alone estimated to carry more than **3,000 live sites**.

The gap between these two figures — roughly 13,000 tower structures versus roughly 35,000 total sites — is itself informative: it implies that a substantial majority of Canadian wireless sites are rooftop, small-cell or other non-freestanding-tower mounting locations rather than purpose-built towers, consistent with the pattern (Section 6) of rooftop being the fastest-permitting and most municipally-preferred structure type. Readers building a bottom-up valuation model should be explicit about which of the two figures — tower-structure count or total-site count — a target's disclosed numbers refer to, since the two are not interchangeable and a source is not always precise about which it means.

1.4 Ownership composition and installation profile

Canadian Tower Ownership Split, 2025

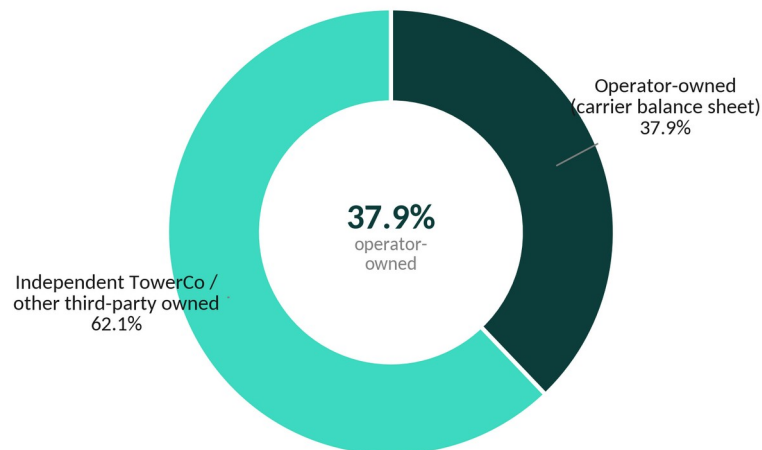


Exhibit 2. Canadian tower ownership split, 2025. Source: Mordor Intelligence.

Mordor Intelligence's segmentation of the Canadian market puts operator-owned towers at approximately **37.9%** of the base, with the balance held by independent tower companies and other third-party owners — a split now moving further toward independent ownership following the transactions described in Section 2, and one industry research pegs the independent segment as growing at roughly **10.75% CAGR**, well ahead of the market's blended 3.56% growth rate. By installation type, the market splits roughly **64% ground-based** to **36% rooftop**; by structure type, the **monopole** is the single largest category at approximately **54.7%** of towers, consistent with its status (Section 6) as the most municipally-acceptable freestanding structure. On power configuration, roughly **66.7%** of sites run a grid/diesel hybrid configuration versus **33.3%** incorporating renewable generation — a data point of growing relevance as ESG considerations enter tower-portfolio underwriting.

1.5 Capital intensity of the wireless sector

Tower economics sit downstream of a large and fairly stable capital-expenditure base across the Canadian telecommunications sector as a whole. Per the Canadian Telecommunications Association, the industry invested:

Year	Wireless capex	Wireline capex	Total industry capex
2022	US\$2.75 billion (~C\$3.79bn)	US\$7.25 billion (~C\$10.00bn)	US\$9.99 billion (~C\$13.79bn)
2023	US\$2.44 billion (~C\$3.37bn)	US\$7.01 billion (~C\$9.68bn)	US\$9.46 billion (~C\$13.05bn)

Year	Wireless capex	Wireline capex	Total industry capex
2024	US\$2.61 billion (~C\$3.60bn)	US\$6.62 billion (~C\$9.13bn)	US\$9.22 billion (~C\$12.73bn)

Source: Canadian Telecommunications Association, Capital Expenditure industry data series; figures are originally reported in CAD, industry-wide (all facilities-based carriers), and are not tower-specific. B² Advisory has converted them to USD at an illustrative rate of C\$1.38 = US\$1.00 (the approximate average USD/CAD exchange rate for September 2026, per x-rates.com) for consistency with the rest of this Report; original CAD figures are shown parenthetically. Columns may not sum exactly owing to independent rounding of each converted figure. These figures are presented here as context for the scale of ongoing network investment that ultimately sustains tower-leasing and tenant-addition demand.

Reading the market data responsibly

The figures in this section are drawn from third-party market-research and government sources and are the best publicly available estimates as of the data-current date on the cover of this report; none of Canada's major carriers or the two active TowerCo platforms discussed in Section 2 publish an audited, tower-specific count or a standardized market-size figure of their own. Investors and executives using this report to underwrite a specific transaction should treat the figures here as a starting reference point for diligence, not a substitute for it, and should validate counts and growth assumptions directly against a target's own disclosed asset registers wherever a transaction is contemplated.



Preview Ends Here

Sections 2 through 14, the glossary, and the full appendix continue in the complete 47-page report.

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